

After Action Review: Tropical Cyclone Winston – Fiji 2016



FIJI, CENTRAL, EASTERN AND WESTERN DIVISIONS
Impacted coastal area, Koro island.

UNDP has conducted an After Action Review (AAR) of its response to Tropical Cyclone Winston that hit Fiji on 20 February 2016. The cyclone, which cut a devastating path through the center of the Fijian Islands, affected over 55,000 people and caused an estimated USD 1.38 billion of damage and losses – one third of Fiji's GDP.

With its response, UNDP demonstrated its relevance in crises settings, proving it could adapt quickly, and that procedures and internal support systems can cope with a rapid onset of difficult situations. Yet, some gaps and challenges may have hampered UNDP's response overall effectiveness and should be further addressed.

UNDP conducted an AAR to help improve its crisis response processes and tools. The review included feedback from national and regional stakeholders, and from UNDP headquarters in New York.

Strengths of Response

A flexible programmatic approach ensured UNDP's relevance. By quickly reprogramming resources from ongoing projects, UNDP commenced a range of 'early recovery' activities.

UNDP's Corporate Crisis Response Packages were adapted to the local context and UNDP extended comprehensive support to ensure results.

UNDP demonstrated value added beyond a first-phase response by supporting national partners as lead UN entity in two of Fiji's most impacted provinces.

Operationally, staff were motivated, committed and active learners.

As an enabling factor, contrasting with TC Pam (Vanuatu/Tuvalu 2015), UNDP had a strong team based at its Pacific Office (PO) in Fiji when the crisis hit, allowing a much quicker response.

A sense of urgency for resource mobilization and strategic thinking in securing CERF funding led to some initial success raising funds.

Government relationships were maintained and the good offices of UNDP (RR/RC) helped moderate between the Government and the international humanitarian community.

HQ and Regional Hub support worked well. Substantial seed-funding was provided by HQ in a timely manner and the comprehensive support of the Crisis Board was key. A rapid deployment of First Responders, including core UNDP staff, ensured much of the immediate response's success. Stand-by partners (SBPs) made essential technical and field management contributions.

Challenges and gaps

At the onset of the crisis UNDP was not well prepared. Staff were not aware of corporate crisis support mechanisms, tools and potential resources.

Crisis response actions were not well anticipated into UNDP's country programme. Ongoing projects did not geographically matched affected areas, and most ongoing projects lacked flexibility for substantial reprogramming.

Operationally, a few bottlenecks emerged largely due to rapid procurement. The crisis took place in a time of structural change and some roles were initially unclear.

UNDP did not clear define 'Early Recovery' or a clear 'UNDP offer' in terms of value in relief and recovery. Early Recovery was not positioned high in the flash appeal. Most UNDP messaging did not reflect the magnitude of the crisis, and the good initial efforts on resource mobilization for crisis response and recovery were not sustained in the long-term.

The scale of response was modest compared to the tremendous needs. At just over USD 1.0 million (80% of which was internally funded), and with few project staff, UNDP's response took time to reach the most affected areas in Ra and Koro.

There was an absence of updated information to determine the actual needs. With a lack of data made available to UN partners, UNDP and others largely responded based on Government requests.

UNDP, and other multilaterals, were unable to engage in national recovery. Following the initial commitment to the PDNA, UNDP and others were unable to sustain sufficient rapport within the Government to ensure a valued role in ongoing post-crisis recovery.

Corporate UNDP policy and guidance for engagement in recovery was lacking. Expectations of what investments in PDNAs should yield needed to be clarified, and further strategic support would have been required for UNDP to develop a definitive offer of value in nationally-led recovery.

Moving forward

Drawing on lessons from TCs Winston and Pam, work continues on preparedness activities in the Pacific, including a UNDP conducted crisis response and preparedness training in Suva for all of the Pacific in January 2017. Specific actions are also needed in country, including a rapid finalization of local level SOPs and preparedness plans with strategies to position on recovery. Reprogramming of existing projects to allow crisis-response flexibility must also be pursued.

In Koro island, UNDP assisted 14 affected villages with debris management activities as well as livelihood and food security recovery, indirectly benefiting over 600 affected households.



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